incidents are completely unrelated, and it is pure coincidence that both masterminds are doctors," deputy inspector general (DIG) Sunil Joshi of the Gujarat ATS tells INDIA TODAY. "Though India is part of the ISKP's vision of a Khorasan province, they do not have a notable physical presence here. It's mostly lone modules, and have been busted by local police. So far, we see no operational link with the Delhi blast."

THE TRAIL WIDENS

On November 12, ATS teams reached Hyderabad and raided Saiyyad's house, assisted by Telangana Police. They allegedly seized about three kilograms of castor pulp, the raw material for ricin; five litres of acetone, a solvent; and equipment like a cold-press oil extraction machine and a tub apparently used to mix the pulp and solvent. Notebooks detailing ricin's biochemical properties and electronic devices purportedly containing incriminating evidence were also recovered. "We did not find finished ricin," says an officer involved in the search. "What we found were the ingredients and indicators of ongoing extraction efforts." Another Telangana officer told reporters the setup "did not look like casual scientific curiosity".

Earlier, a raid on Khan's house in Lakhimpur Kheri yielded an ISIS flag and electronic devices. UP Police sources say the material is being examined for encrypted communications and possible overseas links. Investigators are now trying to understand how the trio was radicalised—both online and through offline nodes. They are also mapping each man's wider circles to uncover other possible associates. According to officers, Saiyyad himself did not know when or how the ricin was ultimately meant to be used, indicating he may have been only one cog in a larger chain. The ATS is also following the money trail to crack the upstream network; investigators say the trio was paid Rs 2 lakh for the task of collecting and transporting the weapons.

THE RICIN THREAT

- **Ricin is a deadly toxin extracted from castor seeds; a few milligrams can trigger organ failure, and there is no antidote**
- **Though the process is simple, it needs trained hands, as unsafe handling can poison the extractor**
- **Despite headline-grabbing cases like ricin letters sent to US presidents, no mass-casualty attack has ever been recorded**
- **Investigators maintain they have found no finished ricin, only "ingredients and indicators of ongoing extraction efforts"**

The discovery has triggered immediate alarm in the Gujarat Police establishment. On November 17, director general of police (DGP) Vikas Sahay ordered all police stations to compile, within 100 hours, updated dossiers on every single case involving anti-national activities registered over 30 years. "We want details of all those booked under the Arms Act or for FICN (Fake Indian Currency Notes) and narcotics cases," a senior ATS officer tells INDIA TODAY. "These individuals are more likely to be tapped by terror networks seeking a foothold in the country."

THE TOXIN ANGLE

Ricin is a toxic protein derived from castor seeds. A few milligrams, ingested or inhaled, can shut down protein synthesis in the body, causing multi-organ failure. Precisely because ricin can be extracted from byproducts of the castor oil industry, it has long caught the attention of extremist groups looking for a low-cost toxin. But extracting it safely requires technical knowledge and the right equipment.

"And motivation," adds Joshi. It is reliably learnt that Saiyyad came from an "extremely orthodox background" and had recently suffered personal upheavals—an early divorce and strained family ties.

Terror groups, investigators say, are often driven by the impulse to innovate. Former Gujarat DGP Ashish Bhatia, a counterinsurgency expert who played a key role in breaking down the Indian Mujahideen network, recalls their earlier flirtations with unconventional substances. "Around 2008, we learnt hydrogen peroxide was being experimented with, but it is so volatile that they couldn't handle it," he says. "Once, they lit a fire in a crowded marketplace. We thought it was local mischief, only to find a terror angle later." With ricin, he suggests, they want to keep public fear simmering.

Globally, ricin has featured in high-profile assassinations and attempted bioterrorism: from the 1978 assassination of Bulgarian dissident Georgi Markov in London using a pellet fired from a modified umbrella to ricin-laced letters sent to US presidents Barack Obama and Donald Trump in 2013 and 2020, respectively; both were intercepted. There have been documented ISIS experiments in Syria and Iraq as well, but despite its notoriety, no mass-scale ricin attack has ever been executed.

While ISKP's core presence lies along the Afghanistan-Pakistan border and Balochistan—not along the India-Pakistan border—recent analyses point to a worrying convergence. Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) is believed to be encouraging coordination between the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) and ISKP. Analysts say this hybrid architecture allows Pakistan plausible deniability while leveraging ISKP's global jihadist brand and LeT's established logistical networks, especially in Kashmir. For Indian agencies, it represents a "high-risk proxy model" that could amplify both the terror's reach and unpredictability. ■